

Boring Technology

Tools old, plain and open enough to outlive the companies that sell them.

Reach for it when a service that holds someone's access is about to be replaced by a platform.

What This Is

Boring technology means tools that are old, plain, and open enough to outlive the companies that sell them.

In practice, that usually means:

- Plain text files
- Ordinary folders
- Formats anyone can open
- Tools that are free and open source
- Copies you keep yourself

A boring tool is not a worse tool. It is one you can still use when something changes.

Why This Exists

Most software today is rented, not owned. You pay every month. It runs on someone else's computers. Your work lives there.

That arrangement is normal, and sometimes it is fine. It also carries a risk that is easy to miss until it lands:

- Prices go up
- Features move behind higher tiers
- Terms change
- Exports get harder
- Companies close, merge, or are sold

When any of that happens, the work you put in is still there — but you may not be able to reach it, move it, or keep it.

Boring technology exists so that a change in someone else's business does not become a loss in your life.

The Words People Use

A few terms come up in this conversation. They are simpler than they sound.

Rentier Someone who makes money by owning a thing and charging for access to it. A landlord does not build you a house each month. They own one, and you pay to stay.

Software as a Service (SaaS) Software you rent instead of buy. It runs on the company's computers. Most apps work this way now.

Technofeudalism The idea that large platforms have rebuilt an old arrangement: a few own the ground, and everyone else works on land they will never own.

Enshittification A common pattern of decline. A platform is good to users first, then worse for users to please paying customers, then worse for everyone to please shareholders.

You do not need these words to protect your work. They are here in case you meet them.

What This Does

- Keeps your originals in formats that stay readable
 - Keeps a copy under your control
 - Makes moving between tools possible
 - Makes your setup understandable to someone else
 - Lowers what it costs you when a service changes
-

What This Does Not Do

- It does not require leaving every paid service
- It does not require running your own servers
- It does not require being technical
- It does not make your work automatically safe
- It does not replace backups

Renting tools is not the problem. Renting the only copy of your work is.

Where Generative AI Fits

Building small tools used to require knowing how to program, or paying someone who did. That cost is much lower now.

AI can help you:

- Write short scripts that do one task
- Explain what an existing setup does
- Write documentation you would not otherwise write

One test is worth applying to anything AI helps you build:

If the AI stopped working tomorrow, would this still run?

If the answer is no, the dependency moved. It did not go away.

Who This Is For

This may be useful if you:

- Run a small organization, classroom, or community project
 - Keep records, research, or writing you expect to need later
 - Have lost access to something because a service changed
 - Are deciding what to buy, adopt, or move to
 - Want a setup someone else could pick up if you were unavailable
-

How to Use This

You do not have to do all of it. Any one step helps.

1. **Pick what matters.** Not everything needs protecting. Find the work you would be sorry to lose.
2. **Keep a copy you control.** On your own device or drive, not only in an account.
3. **Prefer open formats.** Plain text and standard file types over formats only one app can open.
4. **Write down how it works.** A short page is enough. It is what makes a setup survivable.
5. **Check you can get your things out.** Try an export before you need one.

Why It Matters

When a tool changes or closes, the cost does not land evenly.

It lands hardest on people with the least time, money, and energy to move everything at short notice.

Keeping your own copies is one way to make that kind of change survivable rather than costly.

Quick Summary

Own the source. Rent only the convenience.

Keep your originals in plain formats, on something you control. Use whatever tools you like on top of them. If a service ends, you lose a convenience — not the work.

License

This why sheet is free to download, modify, and share.

Version: 0.1 License: “Boring Technology Why Sheet (<https://stimpunks.org/why/boring-technology/>)” is marked with CC0 1.0 (<https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/?ref=chooser-v1>) Repository: <https://github.com/Stimpunks/Why-Sheets/blob/main/Boring%20Technology.md> (<https://github.com/Stimpunks/Why-Sheets/blob/main/Boring%20Technology.md>)

Where this sheet comes from. It is written and revised as Markdown in the open: Boring Technology.md. That file is the source this page and its PDF are both generated from, so the three cannot say different things.

This sheet is also published as a page on stimpunks.org.

There is a one-sheet broadside of this argument — the version you pin up.